that led to Tardi Beg lying in a pool of blood in the Mughal camp, there are various interpretations, reflecting the disquiet felt upon the murder of this old warlord of Babur and Humayun.

According to Abu'l Fazl, there was ancient rivalry between the two men and Bairam Khan, seizing the opportunity of the embarrassing defeat of the Mughals, lured Tardi Beg into his own quarters through an invitation carried via Maulana Pir Muhammad Shirwani*. When Tardi Beg entered the tent, Bairam Khan excused himself on some pretext and Tardi Beg was immediately murdered by his attendants. The young Akbar, all accounts agree, was not present at the time of the killing. He was out hawking, as usual, in the 'delightful plains' of Sirhind with his sparrow hawks. 'When it was reported to him,' wrote Abu'l Fazl, 'no change in his countenance occurred, and he entrusted retribution to almighty God while observing destiny without a wrinkle of complaint on his brow.'

With Tardi Beg out of the way, Bairam Khan now ignored the army's advice to retreat and marched, along with Akbar, to Panipat to confront Hemu. Akbar would not participate in the battle himself, for Bairam Khan kept him at a safe remove, guarded by 3,000 horsemen. About the ancient battlefield of Panipat, a later historian wrote that it was a 'uniform yellow-gray waste of sterile earth. Everywhere empty silence reigns and it would almost seem as if this desert had been designed for the battlefield of nations.' But even without the whimsical imagery of a historian, Panipat would have been charged with sacred symbolism for the Mughal army as the scene of Babur's miraculous victory over Ibrahim Lodi in 1526. Bairam Khan now drew on the memory of that famous victory and gave a rousing speech to his assembled generals. The shoulder blade of a sheep was inspected for good omens and with the assurance that the stars were on their side, the Mughal army readied itself for battle.

Bairam Khan's forces began the day by capturing Hemu's artillery, which had been sent in advance under his generals Mubarak Khan and Bahadur Khan. But after initial jubilation, the Mughals turned to look over the 'sparse grasses and stunted thorn-bushes' of Panipat and saw a sight which must have struck them with scudding fear, battle-hardened warriors though they were, for this was something they had never seen before. It was a vision from a nightmare, or from hell itself. As the earth began to quake beneath their feet and the air was filled with swirling dust, screams, and wails, Hemu charged the Mughals with 1,500 war elephants, all trumpeting